



Rethinking the center-periphery model: Dimensions and temporalities of macro-structure in a global field of cultural production[☆]

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ABSTRACT

A central question in the culture and globalization debate has been how global transformations affect center-periphery hierarchies among countries in realms of cultural production. However, hitherto scholarship has tended to approach the center-periphery distinction in unitary terms. This article extends Bourdieu's model of a dual economy in cultural fields to develop a framework of different types and dimensions of country hierarchies. Taking the contemporary visual arts as a case, it demonstrates that linking the dual economy model with the conceptualization of center-periphery hierarchies offers a more fine-grained lens to examine some of their dynamics. Comparing the evolution of hierarchies among countries in the global auction market and global art exhibition space, the article reveals how center-periphery configurations at the commercial and specific cultural pole of an emerging global field diverge. They follow systematically different patterns and temporalities: whereas the auction market exhibits rapid changes—particularly with the rise of China—, culturally based asymmetries in the global exhibition space are marked by slower transformations along generational cycles of *longue durée*. Although the findings are unique to contemporary art, they indicate that extending Bourdieu's theory may offer tools to go beyond monolithic center-periphery models in cross-border cultural production. It allows to account for the multidimensionality of macrolevel hierarchies as well as their varying logics of change.

1. Introduction

A longstanding question in the culture and globalization debate has been how global transformations affect the structure of hierarchy among countries in realms of cross-border cultural production. As early as the 1970s, scholars of culture/media imperialism denounced cultural globalization¹ as a process that leads to the expanded dominance of a few Western countries (e.g.

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¹ Scholars back then did not use the term "globalization," but referred to similar processes as defined by Crane (2002, 1): "cultural globalization—as opposed to economic, political, or technological globalization—refers to the transmission or diffusion across national borders of various forms of media and the arts."

Schiller, 1976; cf. Crane, 2002). Western centers would continue to command the bulk of resources and wield disproportionate power to influence the production and flow of symbolic goods across borders. Yet already in the 1990s, other voices emerged that questioned such a center-periphery perspective,² arguing that processes associated with cultural globalization were destined to lead to the greater diversification and decentralization among countries and regions in a “new global cultural economy.” Hence, the idea of centers and peripheries appeared no longer useful to grasp what was conceived as an emerging more multipolar and multidirectional constellation (Appadurai, 1990, 33; Tomlinson, 1991).

Fast forward to the new millennium and such dismissal turns out to be premature: a number of studies have demonstrated that stark hierarchies persist in a variety of cultural domains, such as the global book market (Heilbron, 1999; Sapiro, 2010), the global film market (Crane, 2014; Moretti, 2013b), global contemporary art (e.g. Quemin, 2002, 2006; Buchholz & Wuggenig, 2005) or even the universe of “world music” (Brandellero & Pfeffer, 2011). Thus, it seems safe to say that even in a period of accelerated globalization, inequalities among countries do not necessarily lessen; a center-periphery perspective appears still valuable to map cartographies of unequal power in the global cultural economy.

Nonetheless, while research has insightfully shown that strong macrolevel inequalities endure in several spaces of cross-border cultural production, the center-periphery model itself has remained curiously undertheorized. Scholars have tended to invoke it in overly unitary terms. For one, the center-periphery distinction has been used in relation to different *types* of inequalities among countries and correspondingly different types of centrality, which, empirically, do not necessarily overlap. These types of centrality encompass i) geographic centers of cultural mediation, ii) the dominance of a country's cultural/media products in the global marketplace, or iii) a country's position in the global flow and trade of symbolic goods.³ On the other hand, the usage of the center-periphery distinction also has appeared unitary, because the literature has not sufficiently attended to the different dimensions in which country hierarchies manifest, most fundamentally material vs. symbolic ones. As a consequence, we lack a differentiated understanding of center-periphery dynamics in regard to various *types* and *dimensions* of hierarchical relations among countries—a kind of knowledge that could lead beyond an overly monolithic view of territorial power structures and their transformations in the global cultural economy itself.

This article seeks to contribute toward a more differentiated approach to centers and peripheries in global cultural production. I argue that extending Bourdieu's (1993, 1996) model of a dual economy in cultural fields—which distinguishes between specific cultural and economic poles of cultural production and respective hierarchical relations—to a macrolevel offers one fertile path to do so. Building upon this approach, the article develops an analytical framework of different types and dimensions of country hierarchies and distinguishes four related forms of macro-capital. It further suggests that linking Bourdieu's model of a dual economy with the conceptualization of center-periphery hierarchies provides a more fine-grained lens to account for some of their dynamics—and thus to revisit the long-standing question of how global transformations affect the structure of hierarchy among countries in cross-border cultural production.

Empirically, the article exemplifies the utility of a Bourdieusian approach to center-periphery dynamics with regard to the contemporary visual arts. This cultural domain has undergone particularly strong global transformations in the past three decades, leading to the emergence of a global field level of cross-border exchange and competition. Developments encompass the rise of global art circuits; the proliferation of global art discourses and associated construction of a global gaze, as well as new genuinely global modes of hierarchization, such as world-spanning artist rankings (Buchholz 2008, 2013, 2016; cf. also Velthuis & Curioni, 2015). In this sense, the contemporary visual arts offer an especially clear case for investigating dynamics of centers-peripheries in a globalizing field of cultural production. While several studies have examined macrolevel inequalities in contemporary art (op. cit.), they have rarely operated with a Bourdieusian frame. In addition, they have not pursued a systematic comparison of specific cultural and economic dimensions of country hierarchies.⁴

Specifically, the empirical analysis compares the dynamics of country hierarchies by focusing on one type of macrolevel hierarchy and related cross-border centrality—namely the relative centrality of countries' cultural production in global context. By extending Bourdieu's model of a dual economy and drawing upon encompassing data on the market success and cultural prestige of contemporary art from different countries, the study reveals divergent patterns and temporalities in the dynamics of center-periphery hierarchies at the economic and specific cultural pole of the same emerging global field. In the global auction market, center-

² In the sociology of art/art markets, the center-periphery distinction has been employed in a variety of ways that are neither automatically associated with geography nor necessarily global in scope. In this article, I consider only contributions that have drawn upon the center-periphery model in research on culture and globalization and that do so with a geographical emphasis. Within this literature, center-periphery and core-periphery distinctions are sometimes used interchangeably. For reasons of exposition, I will only refer to the center-periphery terminology as a shorthand for the tripartite classification center, semi-periphery and periphery. Center-periphery models operating with a dichotomous logic have rightly been criticized for simplification (cf. Tomlinson, 1991).

³ The difference between the latter two types can be further clarified in light of the distinctive measures that would apply: The former could be assessed by e.g. the share of a country's cultural products in the top segment of a global market (eg. box office hits in the film industry), while the latter by patterns of cultural trade, such as export/import rates or volume and directions of cross-border flows.

⁴ Quemin has pioneered research on country hierarchies in contemporary visual art (e.g. Quemin, 2002, 2006; Quemin & Van Hest, 2015). Yet this line of work has not matched the encompassing ranking analyses with regard to art institutions with equally comprehensive ranking data from the commercial side of the art market. Buchholz has introduced Bourdieu's cultural fields approach to the study of the globalization of contemporary art (Buchholz 2008, 2012, 2013, 2016). This article extends the empirical scope of her earlier comparative work on specific cultural and economic center-periphery asymmetries in contemporary art (Buchholz 2012, 2018). This article is distinct in how it draws upon new data that were derived from a different sampling methodology. It also elaborates a theoretical framework that includes the distinction of four forms of macro-capital.

periphery configurations have undergone relatively rapid changes since the 1990s, a period when the globalization of the art field gained momentum. This especially applies to the remarkable rise of China to a central position. At the same time, the specific cultural pole—i.e. the global exhibition space—has witnessed slower transformations in hierarchies among countries. Nevertheless, contrary to existing studies that emphasize simple reproduction (op. cit.), the article shows that changes of an older West-centric constellation are underway at the specific cultural pole of global contemporary art too—especially regarding the declining centrality of the United States. Yet consistent with Bourdieu's dual economy model, such changes have unfolded more gradually, along generational cycles of *longue durée*.⁵

While these findings are limited to contemporary art, they suggest that extending Bourdieu's dual economy framework may offer a fruitful approach for moving beyond monolithic center-periphery models in research on cross-border cultural production. It provides tools to theorize the multidimensionality of macrolevel hierarchies as well as their varying logics of change. The article develops this proposition in three parts: the first outlines the framework of a multidimensional Bourdieusian approach to center-periphery hierarchies. Afterwards, the database and methodology are described, paying close attention to avoiding Western bias in sampling procedures. The subsequent part presents the findings, which support my argument to distinguish between center-periphery asymmetries at specific cultural and commercial poles of cross-border cultural production.

2. A multidimensional bourdieusian approach to center-periphery hierarchies

2.1. From economic to cultural world-systems

The core-periphery model was originally introduced by Wallerstein to theorize patterns of economic/political domination and exploitation among countries in the economic world system (Wallerstein, 1974). In subsequent appropriations for research on cultural rather than economic production, the model underwent significant mutations. These are worthy to reconstruct first to establish a background against which to spell out how a Bourdieusian approach builds upon existing scholarship, and yet allows to elaborate the model further—for a more differentiated view of macrolevel power structures in “global cultures” (Crane, 2002).

Scholars working on cultural imperialism (e.g. Schiller, 1976; cf. Crane, 2002) were the first to appropriate Wallerstein's core-periphery framework in research on mass-cultural production, aiming to extend his theory of the capitalist world-system to questions of cultural and media-centered dominance. In their view, cultural industries constituted a critical ideological pillar for the world-system's core countries to reproduce their leading positions. Correspondingly, the cross-border dynamics of cultural industries were seen as tightly coupled with the economic system's core-periphery relations as a whole.

Subsequently, alternative approaches developed that I summarize as the cultural world-systems perspective (e.g. Hannerz, 1987, 1992; De Swaan, 1993; Heilbron, 1999; Moretti, 2013a, 2013b). Although they engage with different aspects of culture (e.g. languages, book translations, the modern novel, or film), they converge in a new theoretical orientation: rather than inserting culture into world-systems analysis, they insert elements of world-systems into cultural analysis. The purpose is no longer an extended materialist theory of domination, but an account of domination within globalizing cultural realms. Interestingly, with this new orientation comes an almost unnoticed relabeling into “center-periphery” model, together with at least two shared modifications of Wallerstein's original version.

The first modification consists in the insistence on the relative autonomy of culture. As Hannerz put it, “center/periphery relationships of culture are not (...) a mere reflection of political and economic power” (Hannerz, 1992, 219). They may also be based upon a culturally specific “charismatic geography” (Hannerz, 1992, 229; cf. also Heilbron, 1999, 432). This implies that the position of countries in a cultural world-system can differ from those of the economic system. For example, regarding the contemporary visual arts Japan can be attributed to the cultural semi-periphery in view of the limited cross-border prestige of its artists, although it belongs to the global core economically and politically (Buchholz & Wuggenig, 2005; Favell, 2015). A second modification has been largely overlooked, but is theoretically important. In the cultural world-systems perspective, the center-periphery distinction does not demarcate functional roles within a system of a division of labor, as in some versions of world-systems analysis. Instead, it designates a status variable of the continuous type. That means that centers and peripheries are no longer actor entities that fulfill systemic functions, but structural positions within a continuum of inequalities among countries.

A Bourdieusian approach to centers and peripheries of culture accommodates these modifications and yet, as I explain below, allows to refine the model further in two important directions: by attending to the multidimensionality of country inequalities, and by offering a multileveled framework to relate macrolevel hierarchies with the mesolevel of cultural fields and the microlevel of agents. In what follows, I first outline the basics of a Bourdieusian center-periphery model as pioneered by Casanova (2004) for the cultural realm. Afterwards, I discuss how this model can be elaborated further into a multidimensional framework. Finally, I point out how the refined Bourdieusian approach offers new propositions to study dynamics of centers-peripheries, focusing on the case of contemporary visual art.

⁵ I borrow the concept “longue durée” from Fernand Braudel (2009), who pioneered a plural conception of social times for examining historical patterns. Longue durée designates a form of structural time that pertains to the duration of a historical system as a whole and whose change is less perceptible. It is to be distinguished from “the short term of events or episodic history (for instance political history)” or “the medium term of conjunctures (such as, among others, economic cycles).” (cf. Lee, 2012).

2.2. A bourdieusian approach to centers-peripheries: from individual to macro-capital

Compared with alternative general approaches to the study of cultural production (e.g. Becker, 1982; Peterson & Anand, 2004), Bourdieu's cultural fields theory puts a distinctively strong emphasis on inequalities and respective power imbalances. Yet its national version focused solely on inequalities of agents on micro and mesolevels (Bourdieu, 1993, 1996): individual or organizational 'players' dispose of various forms of cultural, economic, social or symbolic capital.⁶ The volume as well as composition of such capitals in turn predispose their strategies and "position-takings" in ongoing field struggles, ultimately affecting their chances to succeed, or fail.

For moving from national to international/global fields, Bourdieu (2003, 91) and Casanova (2004, 94) suggested to incorporate a macrolevel power structure, whose basics come close to the center-periphery model of the cultural world-systems perspective. In their view, a global field's macrostructure is to be conceptualized as the unequal dissemination of forms of "national capital" among countries. To examine the world literary field, for instance, Casanova introduces the idea of "national literary capital," whose uneven distribution distinguishes literary dominant and dominated countries. These embody the centers and peripheries of the world literary field, with some "median literary spaces" in-between (Casanova, 2004, 277). Added are cities with a high concentration of literary resources, which Casanova depicts as "literary capitals" (Casanova, 2004, 24). They figure as the centers of the centers so to speak—such as Paris in the cultural geography of avant-garde literature. Importantly, Casanova's reference to cities implies that macro forms of capital can relate to different geographic units. Thus, instead of setting "national capital" *a-priori*—and running the risk of "methodological nationalism" (Wimmer & Glick Schiller, 2002)—I propose the more flexible notion of "macro-capital." It can refer to countries, cities or regions, contingent on the case (Buchholz, 2013, 2016). The question whether a global field's structure is mono-centric or polycentric depends on the historically specific distribution of macro-capital, and thus is an empirical one.

Why a macro-structure in global fields analysis? In a global context, the dynamics of field competition often cannot be reduced to mesolevel properties and relations among individual and organizational players. For instance, in regard to the global economic field, Bourdieu posited that a firm's position in the unequal macro-structure among national fields has a "positive or negative multiplier" effect on its chances of success in cross-border competition (Bourdieu, 2003, 91). Something analogous can be said for the arts. In view of the world literary field, for example, Casanova found that originating from a country that is impoverished in literary macro-capital has negative effects on a writer's chances for worldwide recognition. Conversely, a writer from a national field that is rich in resources and thus positively privileged has advantages in worldwide competition by belonging to such a field (Casanova, 2004), in addition to the disposal of her agent level forms of capital. In this sense, a macro-structure is important for understanding power dynamics in global fields when it affects mesolevel competition without being analytically reducible to that level. However, I suggested that the relevance of a macro-structure should not be set universal for all global fields. It is applicable mainly for those that are differentiated along the "vertical autonomy" axis, and thus partially remain interdependent with lower field levels and their forms of capital (national, regional etc.) (Buchholz, 2016, 51).

2.3. A framework of different types and dimensions of centers-peripheries

Casanova's model of center-periphery hierarchies in the world field of literature has been pioneering, but has not exploited the full potential of Bourdieu's fields theory in its attention to multidimensional relations of hierarchy. Building upon her work,⁷ I suggest to further elaborate the Bourdieusian approach in two directions: First, I deem it crucial to decompose two *types* of relative centrality among territorial units that her model had fused, namely in terms of cultural production and mediation/consecration, as I explicate below. Second, I propose to link the conceptualization of centers-peripheries with Bourdieu's idea of a dual economy in fields.⁸ As I will elucidate, this extension entails a differentiation between autonomous (here specific cultural) and heteronomous (e.g. economic) *dimensions* of macro-capital and related inequalities. Both elaborations lead to a four-fold analytical typology of center-periphery hierarchies in cross-border cultural production as presented in Fig. 1. It relies on the shorthand of relative centrality.⁹

Regarding the first extension along the vertical axis in the first column, I argue for disentangling two *types* of relative centrality that Casanova's version of national cultural capital had collapsed: For one, one should distinguish relative centrality regarding cultural production, as indicated by the accumulated prestige of the artistic works of a country, i.e. *specific symbolic macro-capital* (Casanova, 2004, 14–18). On the other hand, there is also relative centrality in cross-border mediation/consecration. The latter hinges e.g. on a country's respective institutional resources, that is, the extensiveness of its "professional 'milieu'" (Casanova, 2004, 15) and art organizations—something that could be differentiated as *specific institutional macro-capital*. To mark this distinction in the first column, we can designate the former 'cultural centrality' and the latter as 'cultural centers' and 'capitals' (i.e. dominant cities).

What speaks for this differentiation of two *types* of relative centrality? Research beyond literature reveals that geographic units

⁶ As is known, Bourdieu distinguishes between four main sorts of capital: Apart from economic capital, he introduced cultural, social, and symbolic capital (Bourdieu, 1986).

⁷ Taking into account that Bourdieu's approach conceives of single fields as particular empirical manifestations of more general field properties, it seems appropriate to build upon her conception of national cultural capital.

⁸ Sapiro (2010) study on the book market has demonstrated the usefulness of Bourdieu's dual economy approach for examining the effects of globalization at the national field level, but the "core-periphery model" at the global level remained unitary.

⁹ In the field approach, center-periphery inequalities are of the continuous type, too. As such, this figure/section uses relative centrality as a terminological shorthand.

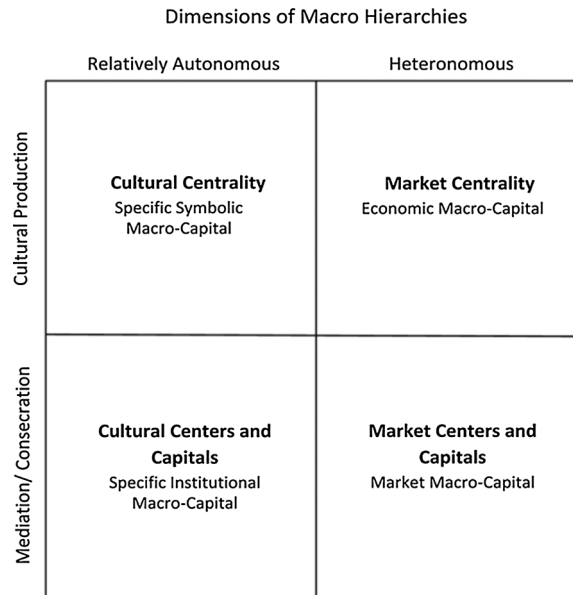


Fig. 1. Types and Dimensions of Relative Centrality in Cross-Border Cultural Fields.

(countries, cities) can occupy different positions when we look at global hierarchies in cultural production or mediation (e.g. Brandellero & Pfeffer, 2011; Phillips, 2013). Center-periphery asymmetries do not have to converge along both types. A striking example is Phillips' insightful study of the international jazz market. While major cities like New York figured as central hubs for the global diffusion of jazz tunes (Phillips, 2013, 51f.), in terms of the success of jazz tunes themselves a "disproportionate advantage" existed for "recordings that emerged from more disconnected cities than when compared with more central cities like New York (...) particularly when the outputs in question are difficult to categorize." (Phillips, 2013, 9, 16). Interestingly, "music from highly disconnected sources tended to have globally broader long run appeal than those originating from [central] places like Chicago and New York." (Phillips, 2013, 51). Thus, insofar as relative centrality in mediation and cultural production does not necessarily overlap, I argue to decompose both types and two related forms of macro-capital.

The second elaboration is to extend these types of centrality with Bourdieu's idea of a dual economy. It posits that cultural fields are fundamentally structured around two poles of the production of symbolic goods with competing principles of hierarchization: a "heteronomous" pole at which competition for economic capital prevails and symbolic goods are primarily evaluated according to their commercial success,¹⁰ and a "relatively autonomous" pole (e.g. Bourdieu, 1993, 115–119; Bourdieu, 1996, 142–146). The latter adheres to an economy of specific cultural legitimacy that, according to Bourdieu, stands in opposition to the heteronomous pole (Bourdieu, 1996). The primary stake is specific symbolic capital, that is, specific cultural recognition by a highly specialized professional public (e.g. artists, critics, curators). Symbolic goods are evaluated on the basis of field-specific criteria, that is, relatively independent from "profane" commercial or temporal considerations (Bourdieu, 1993, 29–73). If one takes this autonomous-heteronomous distinction as the main analytical axis of a field seriously (Bourdieu, 1993, 45ff.) and extends it to a macrolevel, then this suggests that inequalities among countries can differ at both poles. A cultural field in global context may have a bifurcated center-periphery structure. In this sense, Bourdieu's theory offers an angle to conceptualize the multidimensionality of center-periphery asymmetries.

In particular, and returning to Fig. 1, extending Bourdieu's autonomy-heteronomy distinction leads us to a differentiation between cultural and market-related centrality at the level of cultural production, as presented in the first row. Specific symbolic macro-capital can be complemented with *economic macro-capital* to also designate a country's relative commercial success in the global market place, as shown e.g. by sales volume or box-office hits etc. At the level of mediation in the second row, the autonomy-heteronomy axis entails a basic distinction between cultural centers (and capitals) and market centers (and capitals), a duality that can, but must not be manifested empirically in different geographies. Indeed, while in contemporary art NYC has been consistently at the top, in literature this was not the case, with Paris as the preeminent intellectual literary center, and London and New York as major commercial publishing centers (Casanova, 2004, 164–172). Yet it is exactly by being sensitive to such variations that one best distinguishes analytically between cultural and economic centers (and related peripheries) of mediation. Here too territorial units can diverge.

Correspondingly, the notion of a specific institutional macro-capital for cultural centers is to be extended with a second form of *market macro-capital*. Such macro-capital would generally encompass resources and structural configurations that endow certain

¹⁰ As Benson (1999) pointed out, this pole consists not necessarily of market players only, but also of political and bureaucratic forces, particularly the state.

countries (or cities etc.) with advantages to figure as dominant commercial centers in the global marketplace. To take the contemporary visual arts as an example, one may consider e.g. the volume of transnationally operating galleries and auction houses (Buchholz, 2013), the proximity to global financial centers and thus wealthy elites, or certain legal arrangements that ease the sale of art across borders to begin with.

2.4. Dual center-periphery dynamics? The case of contemporary art

Having proposed a refined Bourdieusian framework of types and dimensions of center-periphery asymmetries, this last theoretical section spells out how it can be put to use to examine change. My discussion thereby zooms onto the article's main case—contemporary visual art—and the specific question at stake in the subsequent empirical analysis: How have global transformations in the contemporary art field affected center-periphery asymmetries among countries at the level of cultural production?¹¹ For approaching that question, I shall unpack how linking country hierarchies with Bourdieu's idea of a dual economy offers new hypotheses that depart from existing studies on contemporary art. At the same time, I exemplify how the Bourdieusian model offers a multileveled approach that allows to relate the dynamics of macrolevel hierarchies to the mesolevel of a cultural field and the microlevel of agents' strategies.

Hitherto the literature on the globalization of contemporary art has adhered to a strong reproduction thesis: despite various global transformations, this artistic realm would continue to be dominated by art from a handful of Western countries, whereas art from non-Western countries (i.e. countries in Latin America, Africa, and Asia) would continuously remain peripheral (e.g. Quemin, 2002, 2006; Buchholz & Wuggenig, 2005; Wu, 2009). Quemin suggested a micro-mechanism for this reproduction thesis of a West-centric artistic order: Presuming that certain western centers continue to hold greatest power in cross-border mediation, he argued that intermediaries at these centers—which group into “informal academies” with shared conventions—strongly favor artists from already central Western countries. Such a strategy would allow them to minimize the risks of selection in a highly uncertain evaluation process (Quemin, 2002, 131ff., 147–155).

By contrast, a Bourdieusian approach would lead to different assumptions that question an overly reproductionist view. On the one hand, Bourdieu (1996, 127) suggested that a major motor driving “deep transformations” of hierarchical orders in art fields are morphological expansions, that is, the growth of the populations that are part of it. In view of contemporary art, the emergence of a global field level over the past three decades indeed involved strong morphological changes—with the influx of new artists, new intermediaries, and new collectors from around the world into common emerging global circuits (Buchholz, 2008, 2013). Accordingly, we should expect that the mere reproduction of a West-centric order is unlikely to hold in the long run. On the other hand—and that is the crux of a dual Bourdieusian approach—we should assume that the effects of morphological expansions on countries hierarchies at the level of cultural production would unfold differently at the specific cultural and economic pole in the same emerging global field. Each adheres to its “specific law of change” (Bourdieu, 1996, 154) and temporality. While at the heteronomous pole of the art market the rise of new buyers and thus demand could entail relatively rapid changes in the distribution of economic macro-capital among countries and related hierarchies, at the artistic pole, which revolves around specific symbolic capital, any macrolevel change would unfold only in longer cycles.

Why the latter? Let us first look at Bourdieu's general model of change of specific symbolic hierarchies, before I extend it to global contemporary art. Principally, as already indicated, in a field's autonomous regions the hierarchies among cultural goods tend to hinge on professional specialists (e.g. peer artists, art critics, and curators). Among such specialists, Bourdieu assumes a structural opposition between the “orthodoxy” and “heterodoxy.” This opposition tends to map onto different age groups and constitutes a key mechanism for change: The aesthetic orthodoxy, which is attached to the status quo, frequently consists of older agents with already dominant positions. The “heterodoxy,” by contrast, tends to recruit from newer, often young entrants. Occupying dominated positions, they tend to be hungry to make a name for themselves. And as making a name requires “distinction,” younger aspirants tend to be most predisposed to engage in “subversive,” distinctive strategies that challenge the existing artistic order (Bourdieu, 1996, 154–161, 239–242, 253). The key of this model is that change in the hierarchies among cultural goods (genres, schools, styles) is embedded in generational conflict, whereby the “initiative for change can be traced back, almost by definition, to new (meaning younger) entrants” (Bourdieu, 1996, 239f.). And this is one reason why change unfolds more slowly at a field's relative autonomous pole—along the turning wheels of age groups. Young challengers need to build up recognition over time until they can fully impose their innovative choices and, under favorable circumstances, ascend to a new orthodoxy.

Extended to global contemporary art, this model of change has important and hitherto overlooked implications. For one, it implies that the selection of artists in Western capitals doesn't have to be as risk-averse and static as Quemin suggests. Indeed, since the late 1980s, the art field saw the rise of global discourses that attacked “international contemporary art” for being too Eurocentric, and that called for the greater recognition of artists from non-Western countries, culminating in new visions of “global art” (Buchholz, 2013). Yet with a Bourdieusian perspective we must assume that such discourses resonate especially with less established, younger intermediaries, who, by their position, would be more predisposed to challenge a West-centric aesthetic orthodoxy. If we consider additionally that aspiring intermediaries tend to orient their choices at artists in a similar age range (Bourdieu, 1996, 149–153), and that they need time to accumulate field-specific recognition until they would be able to assert their ‘heretic’ choices, we should expect that changes in a West-centric artistic order unfold more slowly, namely in the rhythm of cohorts. By implication, transformations of

¹¹ As stated in the introduction, the empirical part focuses on *one* type of center-periphery hierarchy at the level of cultural production in both autonomous and heteronomous dimensions.

center-periphery hierarchies at the level of cultural production should be most visible among younger, less established agents. Extending the Bourdieusian model of change at the specific cultural pole provides thereby also a multileveled perspective, because it accounts for the dynamics of macrolevel hierarchies in relation to specific mesolevel structural relations (dominant/dominated, old/young) and cultural ‘rules’ (e.g. distinction), as well as the microlevel of intermediaries’ strategies (orthodox/heretic).

In comparison, variations across age groups should not be observable in the global art market. According to Bourdieu, the heterodoxy vs. orthodoxy polarity does not apply to a field’s heteronomous pole. While his theory is less developed for the market side of fields, it generally suggests that any changes in hierarchies would be driven by more straightforward commercial factors—such as the rise of new consumers. In addition, they would be more susceptible to the external environment, such as broader economic booms. Hence they can unfold more rapidly. Taken together, a Bourdieusian approach would thus lead us to expect changes in an older West-centric order in contemporary art. And yet, it implies, simultaneously, that such changes would follow different temporalities at its specific cultural pole of consecration and at its market pole.

3. Data and methodology

3.1. Sources

To examine whether and how center-periphery dynamics at the level of cultural production differ along the autonomy vs. heteronomy axis in contemporary art, this study drew upon two artist rankings, which were then aggregated at the country level, as explained in the following section. The first was the Artprice ranking. It assesses the economic success of artists in the global auction market, based on their annual sales volume. Auctions tend to differ in price levels from gallery sales (Hutter, Knebel, Pietzner, & Schäfer, 2007). Yet as the auction market represents the most commercial subsegment in contemporary art (Velthuis, 2005), Artprice offered a suitable source for the heteronomous spectrum of the market pole.

For the period under consideration, the ranking relied on information from 2420 auction houses across six continents. Thus, the database’s geographic range was genuinely global. Notwithstanding, the sales data were less complete the more peripheral an auction house was vis-à-vis global art market centers. This limitation particularly applied to the South American region, where some local auction houses e.g. in Brazil or Argentina even refuse to report results. However, insofar as this study focuses on changes at the global field level of contemporary art—whose art tends to sell at highly visible auction houses—this shortcoming could be put at least into perspective. It should be added that the sales data referred to hammer prices only; they did not include the buyer’s premium. This ensured reliability for examining trends over time, since the buyer’s premium can vary significantly. For historical accuracy, all hammer prices were converted into USD according to the exchange rate of the sales day.

The second source, the ArtFacts ranking, assesses the visibility and recognition of artists in the global exhibition space. Based on a vast digital archive of exhibitions from all corners of the world, it ranks 100,000 artists. Nevertheless, for this global database too, the completeness of coverage decreases with peripheral venues and locations. Thus, artists that exhibit in more marginal contexts face added disadvantages in the assessment of their positions. Yet analog to the Artprice source, the effects of these limitations for the study can be considered less problematic, since it concentrates on the global field level of contemporary art.

The ranking’s evaluations operate with a complex multidimensional index that assigns artists “exhibition points” (Artfacts.Net, 2003). Such exhibition points are calculated on a multidimensional base—according to the logic of a weighted index for visibility and reputation—by considering: a) the number of artists participating in the exhibition, with the following weighing of points: solo-shows > group-shows; b) the type of institution: public institutions with a permanent art collection (usually art museums) > no permanent collection (such as contemporary art centers) > galleries; c) geographic location: capital cities with vast numbers of museums and galleries > small cities or towns; d) the relative position of other artists that participate in the exhibition; e) the degree of globality of an artist’s exhibition activities: exhibitions in other cultural regions (e.g. Asia, North-America, Europe) > exhibitions in other countries > exhibition in country of birth. These dimensions are interrelated in a series of equations that determine the weighed sum of an artist’s annual exhibition points. They in turn yield her yearly rank (Artfacts.Net, 2003). It should be underscored that this study relied on *annual* exhibitions points only, without the cumulative logic that underlies published ArtFacts rankings that had been used in prior studies. This temporal specification is critical in allowing proper comparability with the Artprice ranking, which is based on annual sales data only.

To investigate the evolution of inequalities at the specific cultural pole of the global contemporary art field, the ArtFacts ranking offered a fitting source for at least three reasons: first, it comes close to the idea of specific symbolic capital, since ArtFacts seeks to represent first and foremost the evaluation of specialists without straightforward commercial orientations. It deliberately excludes information on sales as well as exhibitions at art fairs or auctions. Instead of success in the market, the ranking aims to capture above all the “curator’s point of view.”¹² Second, for examining trends over time, ArtFacts offers an especially reliable source when compared to an alternative ranking of artistic recognition, the *Kunstkompass*. Instead of drawing from surveys of subjective judgments

¹² Interview conducted with the director Marek Claassen, February 2012. To be sure, the ranking includes gallery exhibitions, because it considers galleries as hybrid brokers between art institutions and commercial ones, like auction houses. However, it decidedly weighs these lowest in comparison to exhibitions at public art institutions. As Susanne Massmann from ArtFacts explains: “We see the gallery (especially the mass of small and middle-sized galleries) as an institution that is definitively part of the market, but also acting like a “meta-artist” in the sense that they are investing in hope and the future with a high risk-taking endeavor, very often accepting the precariat before being called “commercial.” A renown example of this is Betty Parsons Gallery in New York.” (Email, November 16, 2017)

by art professionals whose design may change over time, its data derive from algorithms that are deployed across all exhibitions and years consistently.

Third, the ranking follows a methodology that is in line with the relational logic of field theory (cf. Bourdieu, 1996, 166–173). Its algorithms qualify the relative position of artists by the status of other artists, exhibitions, and cities with which they became associated. This approach also implies that the reputational weight of an art institution or city is not assigned ‘externally’ in quasi-subjective fashion. It results relationally from the association with certain artists, art institutions, and cities itself. Such an interdependent approach to “the dynamics of artistic prestige” has been empirically validated at the national level (De Nooy, 2002). At a global level it has the added advantage that it permits to minimize charges of Eurocentrism, in the sense that certain Western museums or cities would be automatically credited more importance without comprehensive data that would support such identifications.

3.2. Sampling and measurements

The study’s sample encompassed, first, the 100 worldwide leading living “contemporary” visual artists in the ArtFacts and the Artprice ranking in four selected years, namely 1998, 2002, 2007, 2012. The year 1998 was the earliest for which valid global data could be obtained for *both* databases. In turn, the top-hundred threshold was important for the Artprice ranking, because it differentiated artists who compete in the upper price segment of the auction market from those whose prices are lower and whose turnover was primarily determined by the number of lots sold. As the price level is an important indicator of economic success in contemporary art (Velthuis, 2005), this focus was crucial for methodologically justifying the use of the Artprice ranking, since it is based on sales volume. Second, to test for the structuring role of cohorts, we sampled the top 100 living contemporary artist in three cohorts, based on ranking data in the final year 2012. Informed by Bourdieu’s (1996, 155) approach, we distinguished the cohorts by birth year with a time span of 10 years, yielding three cohorts for artists born between 1945–1954, 1955–64, and 1965–74. The study’s sample thus relied on data of 1400 ranked positions¹³ (800 for the upper segments in four selected years, and 600 for the upper segments in three cohorts).

Both ranking databases mix visual artists from various periods and styles. The study had to devise a careful sampling strategy to include only artists that indeed belong to the same category of “contemporary art” in the same global field level of competition. As such, the article departs from prior uses of these databases that drew upon journalistically published, general rankings.¹⁴ Yet, “Contemporary art” is a slippery category. Although its emergence is commonly located in the 1960s (Crane, 1987), it cannot be easily defined in strictly chronological or temporal terms (Danto & Goehr, 1997, 9; Heinich, 2012, 700). And while contemporary art tends to be associated with a transgressive approach to art making (Heinich, 2012), it is notorious for its lack of “stylistic unity” (Danto & Goehr, 1997, 11). The difficulty of ‘operationalizing’ contemporary art becomes exacerbated at the global level. Here different chronologies of “contemporary art” prevail (Belting et al., 2013) and the artistic styles to which the label can apply multiply, much like in a kaleidoscope, in ways that do not always correspond to established Western gazes. Added to these intricacies is the fact that the boundaries of a field—i.e. who belongs to global “contemporary art”—are at stake itself, that is, they are part of internal classification struggles.

Against this background, we ruled out any attempt to operate with an external, quasi ‘objective’ definition. Rather, we pursued an emic strategy, that is, we followed the categorizations that dominant actors internal to the field applied along two steps: First, we drew upon the general demarcation criterion of Artprice and ArtFacts, since both are important players in the global art field themselves (Buchholz, 2013). They categorize contemporary artists as those born in 1945 and after. But this provided only a first, basic delineation. In a second step, we additionally scrutinized whether artists were indeed part of global art circuits as well as included in sales or exhibitions with the label “contemporary art.” In this regard, we used two criteria for the auction source: 1) having been offered at auctions by one of the global players in the market, namely Christie’s or Sotheby’s; 2) having been included in a sale with the label “contemporary art” in the title. For ArtFacts, the first criterion—being part of global art circuits—applies for the upper thousand positions, since globality is integral to the weighting index as outlined above. We checked additionally through extensive biographical analysis to determine whether artists were also exhibited at shows/institutions with the label “contemporary art.” This two-step emic sampling approach may not appear perfect, since it does not attend to aesthetics. But in its emic foundation, it helped to prevent a Western bias in deciding how “contemporary art” should look, and which artists could be associated with it.

Finally, to arrive at measures of macro-capital, we identified the country of origin for every sampled artist. For the thus identified countries we then summarized the percentage shares in exhibition points or sales volume for each of the selected years, following the methodological approach pioneered by Quemin (2002). Correspondingly, a country’s share in the total sum of exhibition points of all included artists in a given year served as an indicator of relative symbolic macro-capital, while a country’s share in the annual auction revenue generated by all sampled artists in that year assessed relative economic macro-capital.

For the comparative analysis of the distribution of symbolic and economic macro-capital among countries, the analytic focus was directed to three sub-questions: first, we investigated whether there had been changes among top positions, and in this sense in patterns of centrality among countries. Second, we explored transformations in the overall structure of hierarchy. On the one hand,

¹³ Note that 1400 ranked positions of artists does not mean that the sample contained 1400 artists, since there can be overlap between the selected years and cohorts.

¹⁴ For example, the regularly published Artprice list of the top 500 contemporary artists discriminates only by birth year of the artists. It does not consider the actual artistic styles or the kind of auction houses (global or national) at which work is being sold.

we scrutinized the degree of concentration in symbolic and economic capital among included countries, which we measured by the normalized Herfindhal-Hirschman index (HHI). The Herfindhal-Hirschman index is generally defined as $HHI = \sum s_i^2$, with s_i the share of each statistical individual, which in this study are countries. The normalized Herfindel-Hirschman is calculated as $H^* = \frac{(H - 1/N)}{1 - 1/N}$. This measure has been used to assess the degree of concentration in markets, but also for research on cultural production (cf. Benhamou & Peltier, 2007). Third, we examined the share of Western vs. non-Western countries, corresponding to the question of whether globalization entailed changes in a West-centric order in contemporary art. Our respective classification relied upon Galtung's (2000) meta-geographical category of the "Northwest," encompassing North America and Western Europe.¹⁵ This categorization corresponds most closely to how the literature on culture and globalization refers to the "West" vs. "non-West" distinction, although it has not provided an explicit definition of it.

4. The dual dynamics of centers-peripheries in the globalizing contemporary visual arts

4.1. The divergence of center-periphery configurations at the market and specific cultural pole

Table 1 shows the evolution of country inequalities in the global auction market and global exhibition space from 1998 to 2012. The shares of countries for each year are listed from highest to lowest percentages. Focusing first on dynamics at the market pole as

Table 1

The Unequal Distribution of Macro-Capital in the Top Segment of the Global Art Auction Market and Global Exhibition Space, 1998–2012 (Percent Per Annum).

1998				2002				2007				2012			
Economic		Symbolic		Economic		Symbolic		Economic		Symbolic		Economic		Symbolic	
USA	35.5	USA	26.8	USA	39.8	USA	25.6	China	43.8	USA	25.4	China	41.6	USA	29.8
Germany	16.9	Germany	14.5	Germany	16.6	Germany	14.0	USA	19.0	Germany	13.6	USA	24.6	Germany	14.6
UK	15.7	Switzerland	10.2	UK	13.5	UK	11.5	UK	16.6	UK	10.7	UK	8.5	UK	10.8
Italy	5.2	UK	7.3	Spain	8.4	Switzerland	4.4	Germany	6.6	Switzerland	5.1	Germany	6.9	Austria	3.5
Cuba	4.2	China	6.5	Italy	7.3	Japan	3.7	Japan	3.4	South Africa	4.4	Japan	3.9	South Africa	3.3
Spain	3.8	France	4.7	Japan	4.4	South Africa	3.3	India	2.8	Austria	3.9	India	2.3	Poland	3.2
France	3.4	Austria	4.0	France	1.6	Canada	3.2	Italy	2.8	France	2.6	Brazil	2.1	Israel	3.0
Argentina	2.2	Italy	3.6	Netherlands	1.6	Austria	3.1	Spain	1.4	Mexico	2.6	Italy	1.9	France	2.7
Uruguay	2.2	Belgium	3.2	China	1.2	Belgium	2.5	South Africa	0.7	Canada	2.3	Spain	1.4	Belgium	2.0
Austria	1.5	Denmark	3.2	Ireland	1.0	France	2.4	Denmark	0.5	China	2.2	Ireland	1.1	Switzerland	2.0
Canada	1.4	South Africa	2.7	Iran	0.8	Italy	2.3	South Korea	0.5	Belgium	2.0	South Africa	0.9	Lebanon	1.8
Ireland	1.4	Canada	1.8	Australia	0.7	Ireland	2.1	Ireland	0.4	Denmark	2.0	Canada	0.8	Cuba	1.7
India	1.1	Thailand	1.5	Brazil	0.7	Mexico	1.4	France	0.3	Cuba	1.8	Switzerland	0.8	China	1.6
China	1.0	Japan	1.4	Cuba	0.6	Brazil	1.4	Iran	0.3	Poland	1.7	Cuba	0.4	Albania	1.6
Mexico	0.9	South Korea	1.4	Argentina	0.4	South Korea	1.4	Switzerland	0.3	Lebanon	1.5	France	0.4	Canada	1.6
Bahamas	0.6	India	1.1	Austria	0.4	Lebanon	1.2	Brazil	0.2	Lithuania	1.5	Iraq	0.4	Italy	1.5
Brazil	0.5	Bulgaria	1.0	Canada	0.3	Australia	1.2	Cuba	0.2	Netherlands	1.4	Philippines	0.4	Ireland	1.5
Chile	0.5	Lebanon	1.0	India	0.3	Iran	1.2	Indonesia	0.2	Serbia	1.3	Serbia	0.4	Morocco	1.4
Taiwan	0.4	Netherlands	0.9	Chile	0.2	Ivory Coast	1.1			Israel	1.1	Taiwan	0.4	Serbia	1.2
Australia	0.3	Serbia	0.9	Lebanon	0.2	Lithuania	1.1			Brazil	1.1	Indonesia	0.3	Chile	1.1
Japan	0.3	Australia	0.8			Albania	1.1			Romania	1.1	Puerto Rico	0.3	Vietnam	1.0
Lebanon	0.3	Ireland	0.8			Serbia	1.1			Japan	1.0	South Korea	0.2	Japan	0.9
Peru	0.3	Cuba	0.7			Spain	1.1			Spain	0.9			Iran	0.9
Netherlands	0.2					Bulgaria	1.0			Italy	0.8			Denmark	0.9
Venezuela	0.2					Finland	1.0			Algeria	0.8			Mexico	0.8
						Netherlands	0.9			Iran	0.8			Thailand	0.8
						Denmark	0.9			Albania	0.8			Netherlands	0.7
						Vietnam	0.9			Chile	0.7			Croatia	0.7
						Portugal	0.9			Kenya	0.7			Algeria	0.7
						China	0.8			Bulgaria	0.7			Brazil	0.7
						Cameroon	0.8			Argentina	0.7			Slovenia	0.7
						Cuba	0.7			Australia	0.7			Spain	0.7
						Turkey	0.7			India	0.7			Bulgaria	0.6
										Croatia	0.7				
										Sweden	0.7				
N = 25	N = 23	N = 20	N = 33	N = 18	N = 35	N = 22	N = 33								
HHI = 0.15	HHI = 0.08	HHI = 0.18	HHI = 0.08	HHI = 0.22	HHI = 0.08	HHI = 0.21	HHI = 0.10								

Sources: Artprice.com, ArtFacts.Net.

¹⁵ "Western Europe" was defined as including all member states of the *European Union* before the Eastern European expansion in 2004.

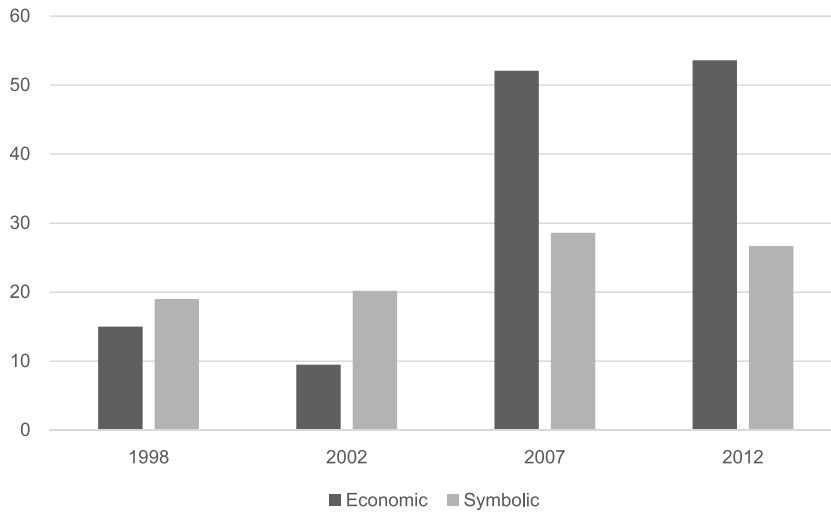


Fig. 2. The Share of Non-Western Countries in Economic and Specific Symbolic Macro-Capital in the Top 100 Segment (Percent Per Annum). Sources: Artprice.com, ArtFacts.Net.

represented in the left columns, one can discern remarkable changes among central countries. In 1998, the distribution of economic macro-capital was still heavily concentrated on three Western countries. The US dominates, since 35.5 percent of all the auction revenue in the upper segment of that year was generated by US-American artists. It is followed by Germany (16.9), and the UK (15.7). Yet only around a decade later, this West-centric configuration changed: in 2007 China (43.8) rose to a leading country in the global auction market, while the US (19) fell to a second position, with around half of China's share in that year. This considerable change was not short-lived. In 2012, China (41.6) continued to be the leading country in the contemporary art auction market, while the US (24.6) stayed second.¹⁶ Another noticeable tendency in the same period was Germany's decline. It fell from a second position in 1998 (16.9) to a relatively feeble fourth in 2007 (6.6) where it remained until 2012 (6.9), moving closer to the market's semi-periphery.

These transformations among central positions went along with a general demise of Western dominance in the upper tier of the auction market. The market share of non-Western countries more than tripled from 1998 (15) to 2012 (53.6, cf. Fig. 2), leaving Western countries—which in 1998 concentrated three quarters of economic macro-capital—with a share of less than half. In addition to China's extraordinary rise, this trend was also related to the appearance of other Asian countries. They encompass Japan (3.9) and India (2.3), albeit in the still more semi-peripheral range, as well as Iraq, Philippines, Taiwan, Indonesia and South Korea in the market's periphery.

By contrast, symbolic country inequalities in the upper tier of the global exhibition space show much more inertia, as represented at the right-side columns of Table 1. The most central positions of the US (29.8) and Germany (14.6) remained uncontested throughout this period, with very little change in symbolic macro-capital in the final year. Only the third position underwent a transformation, but remained within Western Europe. It shifted from Switzerland in 1998 (10.2) to the UK in 2002 (11.5). While these results no longer resemble the extreme dominance of a "US-German duopoly" reported in prior work (cf. Quemin, 2002, 2006, 543f.; Buchholz & Wuggenig, 2005; Quemin & Van Hest, 2015),¹⁷ they underline that three Western countries still commanded most centrality in the top segment of the cultural pole, even when, in the same period, a country from Asia conquered a central position in the market.

The impression of stability in the upper tier of the global exhibition space amplifies when one follows general trends in the structure of country hierarchies. While the period witnessed considerable geographic extension from 23 to 33 countries, the concentration of symbolic macro-capital hardly dissolved in lockstep: on the contrary, the HHI slightly increased from 0.08 in 1998 to 0.10 in 2012 (the higher the value, the more concentration). Furthermore, the share of non-western countries rose 8.7 percent only (from 19 to 27.7, cf. Fig. 2), a movement much weaker than in the auction market, where the net surge was 38.6 percent. Interestingly, China underwent an almost inverse trajectory in the global exhibition space, since its position declined from 6.5 percent in 1998 to a weak 1.6 percent in 2012. This finding supports the argument that the pole of specific symbolic capital and the market pole follow divergent logics and temporalities in a period of accelerated globalization.

¹⁶ This finding on China's ascent in the auction market extends earlier studies on a methodologically more robust basis (cf. Buchholz, 2012, 2013, 2018; Quemin & Van Hest, 2015). As these results derive from an especially discriminating sampling strategy, China's rise cannot be discounted as merely a local phenomenon in global disguise (Quemin, 2012, 63). The sampling also safeguarded against a too loose application of the label of contemporary art, as in the Artprice rankings published in a journalistic format. By delineating "contemporary" artists by birth year only (born 1945 and after), the latter mix (Chinese) artists with different stylistic orientations, including ink art, calligraphy or traditional oil painting—a mix that can heavily distort the results, because traditional Chinese art tends to achieve higher auction price levels than contemporary production.

¹⁷ The latter study draws from ArtFacts data that were published in the German magazine *Kunstmarkt Kompass*. As outlined in the methodology section, the results in this article derive from a theoretically based sampling strategy that also ensured comparability with the Artprice source. It controlled for age, time unit, and annual rather than cumulative exhibition points.

4.2. The transformation of western dominance across cohorts at the specific cultural pole

The comparison between the global auction market and the global exhibition space confirms the hypothesis of different dynamics of economic and culturally based center-periphery hierarchies. It thereby demonstrates that symbolic macro-capital shows a stronger tendency of reproduction in the top segment. However, once we take into account the “specific law of change” (Bourdieu, 1996, 154) at a field’s specific cultural pole and dissect cohorts, the picture of simple reproduction weakens.

As the right columns of Table 2 detail, transformations of symbolic inequalities among countries are underway, too. Yet, they follow a more gradual rhythm. As predicted by the Bourdieusian model, we find systematic variation between age groups in 2012: The younger the cohort, the more decentralized and de-westernized the structure of symbolic country hierarchies. A steady expansion of included countries from 26 to 33 to 38 goes hand in hand with steadily less concentration of symbolic macro-capital. In fact, the HHI declines from 0.18 to 0.07 until it reaches merely 0.04.¹⁸ Moreover, the share of non-Western countries rises considerably: it consisted of 17.9 percent among the oldest, and more than doubled among the youngest, reaching 40.5 percent (cf. Fig. 3).¹⁹

Table 2

The Unequal Distribution of Macro-Capital in the Global Art Auction Market and Global Exhibition Space Among Three Cohorts in 2012 (Percent Per Cohort).

1945-1954			1955-1964			1965-1974					
Economic		Symbolic	Economic		Symbolic	Economic		Symbolic			
China	28.8	USA	42.4	China	43.2	USA	21.6	UK	37.9	Germany	12.6
USA	25.9	Germany	13.7	USA	27.7	Germany	14.4	China	24.7	USA	12.3
Germany	17.4	UK	8.0	Japan	5.7	UK	11.2	USA	18.4	UK	12.1
India	6.6	Austria	5.0	Germany	4.5	Belgium	5.1	Germany	4.2	Israel	4.6
Ireland	3.6	South Africa	3.4	Brazil	3.6	Switzerland	4.5	Indonesia	2.8	Austria	3.7
Canada	3.0	Canada	3.2	Italy	3.3	France	4.3	Switzerland	2.7	Morocco	3.7
Japan	2.6	Italy	2.6	UK	2.7	Austria	4.2	Philippines	1.8	Poland	3.7
UK	2.2	France	2.5	Spain	2.6	China	3.6	France	1.3	Italy	3.6
South Africa	1.6	Japan	2.4	Belgium	0.9	Brazil	2.6	Puerto Rico	1.2	Albania	3.4
Cuba	1.4	Serbia	2.4	South Africa	0.9	Canada	2.6	Belgium	0.8	Denmark	3.4
Italy	1.3	Switzerland	1.8	Taiwan	0.9	South Africa	2.6	Poland	0.7	Mexico	3.0
Serbia	1.2	Lebanon	1.6	France	0.7	Mexico	2.1	Israel	0.5	Cuba	2.9
Turkey	0.7	Croatia	1.2	South Korea	0.6	Italy	1.8	Denmark	0.4	Belgium	2.8
France	0.5	Ireland	1.2	India	0.5	Netherlands	1.8	Ethiopia	0.4	Lebanon	2.8
Taiwan	0.5	Argentina	1.0	Switzerland	0.5	Chile	1.7	Norwegian	0.3	France	2.7
Uruguay	0.5	Czech Rep.	1.0	Mexico	0.3	Spain	1.4	Kenya	0.3	Netherlands	2.6
Austria	0.4	Portugal	1.0	Turkey	0.3	Thailand	1.4	South Korea	0.3	Spain	2.1
Brazil	0.4	India	0.9	Iran	0.3	Bulgaria	1.3	Turkey	0.3	Algeria	1.2
Switzerland	0.3	China	0.8	Denmark	0.3	Ireland	1.1	Egypt	0.2	Croatia	1.1
Australia	0.2	Belgium	0.7	Argentina	0.2	Iran	1.0	Thailand	0.2	Russia	1.1
Costa Rica	0.2	Romania	0.6	Venezuela	0.1	Colombia	0.9	Italy	0.2	Slovakia	1.1
Iran	0.2	Slovenia	0.5	Sweden	0.1	Denmark	0.9	Brazil	0.2	China	1.0
South Korea	0.2	Bosnia/Herzegovina	0.5	Colombia	0.1	Israel	0.9	Canada	0.2	Hungary	0.9
Lebanon	0.1	Brazil	0.5			Sweden	0.9			Romania	0.9
Russia	0.1	Pakistan	0.5			Argentina	0.8			South Korea	0.9
Spain	0.1	Poland	0.5			Lithuania	0.8			Vietnam	0.9
						Japan	0.7			Canada	0.8
						Poland	0.7			Georgia	0.8
						South Korea	0.7			Iraq	0.8
						Pakistan	0.6			Kenya	0.8
						Romania	0.6			Switzerland	0.8
						Serbia	0.6			Thailand	0.8
						Vietnam	0.6			Egypt	0.7
										Ethiopia	0.7
										Iran	0.7
										Turkey	0.7
										Venezuela	0.7
										Chile	0.6
N = 26	N = 26		N = 23	N = 33		N = 23	N = 38				
HHI = 0.16	HHI = 0.18		HHI = 0.24	HHI = 0.07		HHI = 0.21	HHI = 0.04				

Sources: Artprice.com, ArtFacts.Net.

¹⁸ These values differ also from the cultural pole’s total upper tier in 2012. The latter encompasses 33 countries and amounts to a clearly higher degree of concentration with a HHI of 0.1 (cf. Table 1).

¹⁹ This is an evident difference also to the share of 27.7 percent in the total upper tier of the global exhibition space in 2012 (cf. Table 1).

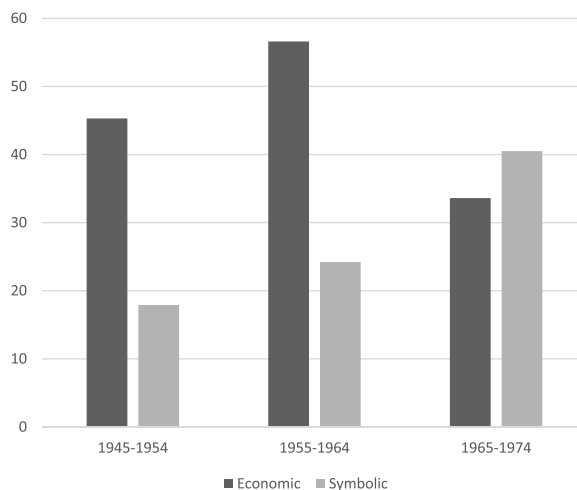


Fig. 3. The Share of Non-Western Countries in Economic and Specific Symbolic Macro-Capital Among Three Cohorts in 2012 (Percent Per Annum). Sources: Artprice.com, ArtFacts.Net.

The latter growth is above all related to the increasing presence of non-Western countries in the semi-peripheral range (from around < 7 to 2 percent), with a mix from Asia (Israel and Lebanon), North Africa (Morocco), Eastern Europe (Poland, Albania), as well as Latin America (Mexico, Cuba). However, the dynamics among central positions also offer evidence for a more decentralized and de-westernized structure across cohorts, namely regarding the continual decline of the US. While it occupied with 42.4 percent an almost hyper-central position among the oldest,²⁰ its share significantly shrank to 12.3 percent among the youngest, placing it second after Germany (12.6) and only slightly before the UK (12.1). Although the three most central positions thus stay within the Western hemisphere, with a collective 37 percent, they possess a lower share in symbolic capital than countries from outside the West in the youngest cohort. In this sense, it seems justified to speak of a transformation of Western dominance across cohorts, without, however, claiming a radical change.

In the global auction market, by contrast, no systematic variations are observable across cohorts (cf. left columns of Table 2). While the number of countries declines from 26 to 23 and then stagnates at 23, the degree of concentration in the market follows a non-linear pattern, with the HHI ranging from 0.16 to 0.24 and 0.21. An even more pronounced non-linear trend applies to the share of non-Western countries, moving from 45.3 to 56.7 and then declining to 33.6 (cf. Fig. 3), the latter value being particularly related to China's descent to a second rank in the youngest cohort. Such volatile changes can be due to an array of complex factors that go beyond the scope of this article. Importantly, they corroborate the hypothesis that the heteronomous market pole differs in its patterns of change across cohorts from the specific cultural pole.

Lastly, it should be added that the transformation of Western dominance across cohorts does not necessarily mean that Western countries lose their dominance at the level of mediation in parallel ways. As section 2.3 argued, we should distinguish between types of country hierarchies regarding cultural production and mediation. Indeed, an examination of the geography of exhibitions of artists from non-Western countries in the youngest cohort confirms the value of making such a distinction.²¹ As Fig. 4 indicates, the US, Germany and France still figured as key countries for showcasing their work in 2012, while additional research revealed that New York, Paris, Zurich, Berlin and London were the most frequented cities. And, if one looks more closely at solo-exhibitions, almost three quarters clustered in countries from the Northwest, which suggests that they still wielded greatest consecration power in the global exhibition space for artists from non-Western countries.²²

Significantly, these findings underline that an account of artistic selection processes in Western capitals that relies on the idea of risk-averse “informal academies” is not sufficiently complex. It involves an understanding of strategies of aesthetic selection among intermediaries that is too consensual and static. The geography of exhibitions revealed here rather suggests that globalization in contemporary art has had effects on the logic of competition and strategies of distinction among curators in Western art centers in the new millennium, too. There appears indeed a growing inclination to engage in “heterodox,” that is, more global choices of artists vis-à-vis an older Western artistic orthodoxy. Yet in a Bourdieusian perspective, innovative strategies tend to be enacted by younger aspirants along their artistic peers. These typically need to build up field-specific recognition until they would be able to fully establish their ‘heretic’ agendas. Correspondingly, transformations of a West-centric artistic order at the specific cultural pole only

²⁰ Heilbron (1999, 433) introduced the notion of a hyper-central position in his study of book translations.

²¹ Information about the geographical distribution of exhibitions in the year 2012 (the year from which the cohorts were drawn) was derived from ArtFacts.Net. It lists for each artist the institutions and locations in which they presented their work.

²² The exact figure is 73%. Similar distributions apply to the geography of solo-shows of non-Western artists from the middle and oldest cohort, with 76 and 74 percent located in countries of the West respectively. These figures resonate with earlier findings on the global careers of contemporary artists that rank high at the cultural pole, which underscored the singular importance of solo-shows at Western capitals (cf. Buchholz, 2013).

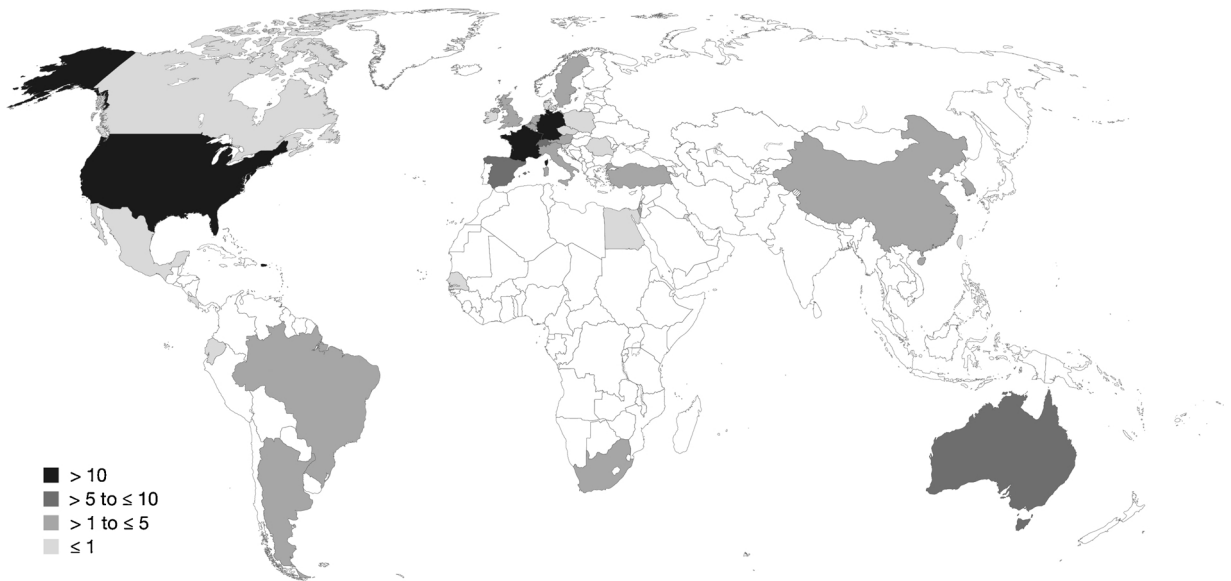


Fig. 4. The Geography of Exhibitions of Artists from Non-Western Countries from the 1965-74 Cohort in 2012 (Percent).
Source: ArtFacts.Net.

become visible if one pays closer attention to the peculiar social rhythm across cohorts that tends to underlie a field's dialectic of distinction—also when the game globalizes.

5. Discussion

This article investigated how global transformations have affected center-periphery configurations in the contemporary visual arts. I have argued that in order to examine such dynamics, it is necessary to distinguish between different types and dimensions of macrolevel hierarchies. And I have suggested that extending Bourdieu's theory of a dual economy in cultural fields provides one avenue toward a multidimensional approach to center-periphery hierarchies. The analysis revealed that if we transpose his autonomy vs. heteronomy distinction, we can discern that center-periphery configurations at the level of cultural production follow divergent patterns *and* temporalities at the economic and specific cultural pole of an emerging global field. Whereas the auction market is characterized by comparatively rapid, yet more volatile patterns, the global exhibition space is marked by cycles of *longue durée*, characteristic of more autonomous subspaces with charismatic structure in which change tends to unfold more gradually across cohorts.

These findings question the predominant reproduction argument in scholarship on the globalization of contemporary art. Extending Bourdieu's dual economy model—with its theoretically grounded distinction of hierarchical dimensions and respective logics of change—the analysis uncovers a more complex set of dynamics, marked by the simultaneity of shorter and longer cycles in which transformations of center-periphery configurations at the level of cultural production can occur. Thus, I propose an alternative transformational perspective: it acknowledges that globalization impulses in contemporary art have had effects on an older West-centric artistic order and related practices of mediation. Simultaneously, it does not go into an opposite “globalist” extreme and proclaims the latter's complete demise.²³ The article's discovery that the transformational effects of globalization are partly mediated across age groups could thereby be further explored in light of the theory of global generations (Edmunds & Turner, 2005) also beyond contemporary art.

The study additionally bears implications for scholarship that presumes a strong interdependency between cultural and economic inequalities in the visual arts (e.g. Moulin, 1992; Quemin, 2002, 2006; Beckett & Rössel, 2013), positing even growing convergence in a period of accelerated globalization (Graw, 2009). By contrast, this article adds macrolevel evidence for the model of a dual cultural world economy (Buchholz, 2013). It contends that in the globalizing art game instead of convergence we find divergence—economic and symbolic capital follow increasingly divergent rules and dynamics of valuation. At the same time, the theory underlines that the institutional basis for such divergence in the global context is a rather different one from Bourdieu's 19th century account (Bourdieu, 2017)—particularly in view of the rise of financial logics (cf. also Velthuis & Coslor, 2012; Shin, Lee, & Lee, 2014).

The study has several limitations that need to be pointed out. First, it has only dealt with center-periphery inequalities at the level of cultural production, rather than places of mediation. While the article suggested the analytical distinction of cultural and market

²³ For the distinction between globalist, skeptical and transformational positions in the “great globalization debate” see Held and McGrew et al. (2003).

centers in cross-border mediation, hitherto Bourdieu's approach seems less developed for theorizing the dynamics of the latter. Further research might benefit from insights on the spatiality of cultural industries (Scott, 2000) as well as the role of place in culture making (Oberlin & Gieryn, 2015)—especially in view of world art cities (While, 2003)—to push into a more comparative direction on unequal center-periphery dynamics of mediation. It would be interesting e.g. to explore under what conditions cultural and market centers converge or diverge in global fields, or how and why there might be different degrees of centralization in cross-border mediation over time.

Second, the article employed only data from auctions, and thus the most heteronomous market segment. It did not use sales data from galleries, which are notoriously difficult to obtain. As the latter tend to be more heterogeneous and include organizations with autonomous orientations, we should expect less pronounced divergences. Lastly, this study is entirely macro-structural. For a more complete understanding of the role and dynamics of country hierarchies in contemporary art, we certainly need research at meso and microlevels, too. In particular, we need to understand better the interpretative as well as relational processes through which hierarchies among countries influence choices of intermediaries and translate into value judgements (e.g. Buchholz, 2018). Such research naturally needs to venture into a more meaning-oriented, even “Post-Bourdieuian” direction (Beljean, Chong, & Lamont, 2016); and it could profit from the cultural wealth of nations approach (Bandelj & Wherry, 2011).

Notwithstanding these limitations and the fact that the findings are confined to contemporary art, the proposed theoretical framework may offer a useful angle for a more fine-grained, multi-dimensional perspective on center-periphery hierarchies in global cultural production. At a stage in which empirical work strives to disaggregate layers and dimensions of the cultural globalization process to better capture its nuances and complexities, the framework's distinctions can contribute to also fine-tune macro variables that inform large-scale research. My argument is not that we see necessarily similar changes in other globalizing cultural fields. Especially the rapid rise of China at the market pole seems a strong development that might not be easily replicated. A Bourdieusian fields approach does not ‘predict’ which countries rise to the top and which decline, analog to Wallerstein's world-systems analysis. Nor does it tell us exactly in which time frames. Rather my theoretical point is that by distinguishing between subspaces and their unique modalities of hierarchization and change, we can develop a more refined picture of macrolevel hierarchies and how they transform, and how such processes are mediated by field-specific logics in particular historical contexts. A Bourdieusian approach is thus not just about reproduction, but also change—offering a springboard for a multidimensional and multileveled understanding of power dynamics in the global cultural economy.

Conflicts of interest

None.

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